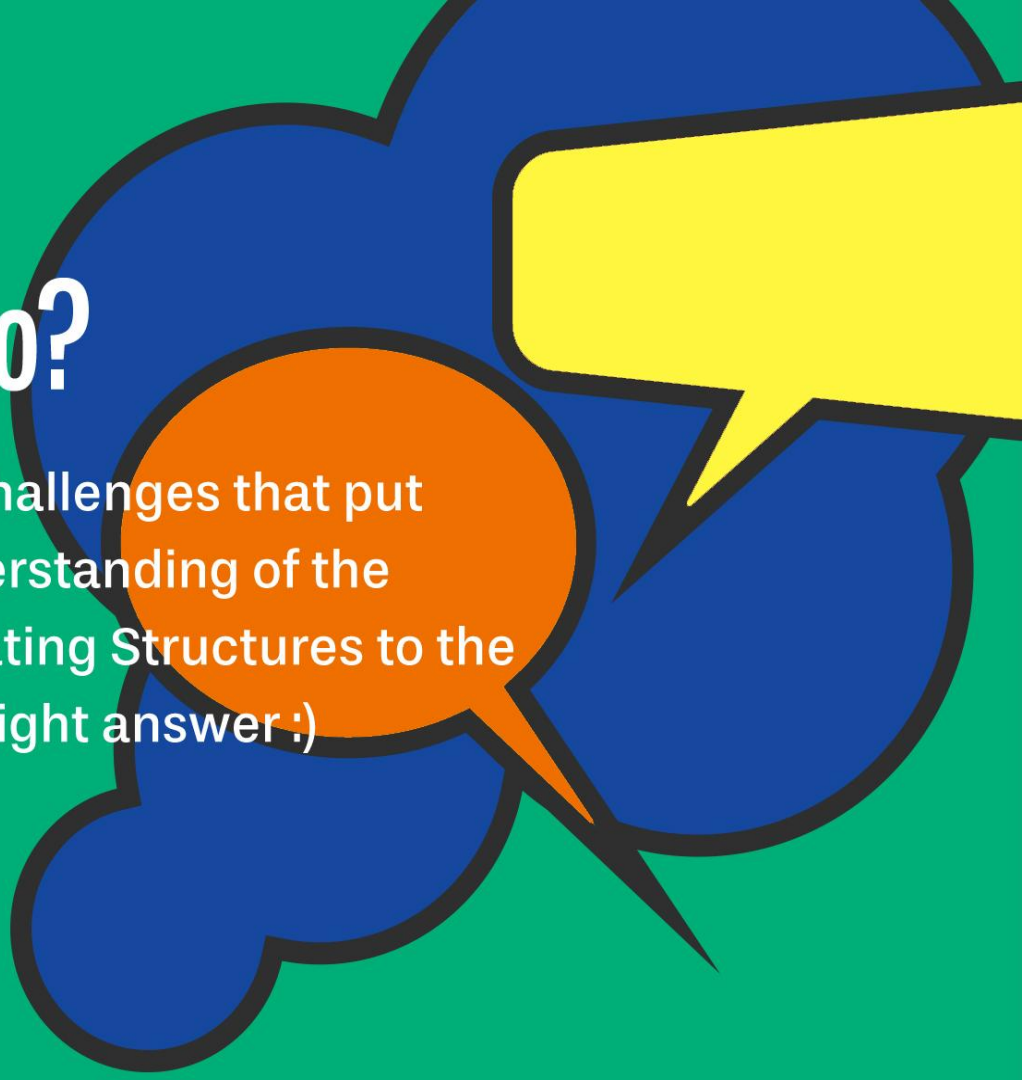


What Would You Do?

A series of cases and real-life challenges that put your principles, values and understanding of the Scrum Framework and/or Liberating Structures to the test. And no, we don't have the right answer :)

**The
Liberators**

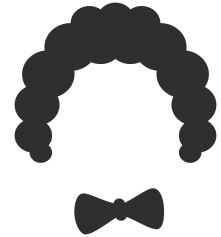


52 Challenging Cases for Scrum Masters & Scrum Teams

The [Scrum framework](#) is a lightweight framework to solve complex and adaptive problems with others. Although it looks easy on paper, it's often much harder to do well in the messiness of the real world. Where do you make trade-offs? How can you model the Scrum values? How can you work empirically in an environment that isn't suited for it?

This deck contains 52 real-life cases that are inspired by our own experiences and those of the people we frequently work with.

Use these cases for your community of Scrum Masters, as conversation starters in and around your Scrum Team, or put your own understanding of Scrum to the test. And no, there is no “right answer” :)



*All cases are created by The Liberators -
Barry Overeem & Christiaan Verwijs.*

*This deck was purchased from <https://shop.theliberators.com>.
Please treat the effort we put into creating it with respect and don't
distribute it to others.*

Use Liberating Structures to Make Sense of the Cases Together

We purposefully wrote each case in such a way that there is no clear “right” answer. Instead, there are different sides to each case, different arguments to make and different solutions - some better than others. Just like the real world ...

For the best learning experience, use [Liberating Structures](#) to structure the conversation. That way, everyone can offer their perspective. You may even find creative solutions to your own challenges!

We always like [Conversation Cafe](#) to dig into cases like these. You can follow-up with [15% Solutions](#) or [1-2-4-ALL](#) to translate learnings from the case to your own team or environment.

Other useful Liberating Structures:

- [1-2-4-ALL](#)
- [Impromptu Networking](#)
- [User Experience Fishbowl](#)
- [What, So What, Now What?](#)
- [Discovery & Action Dialogue](#)
- [Improv Prototyping](#) (act out the case for added realism - and fun!)

**What Would
You Do?**

Scrum outside product development

You've been doing work as a freelance Scrum Master. So far, all your experience has been with software development. But recently, you were contacted by a government agency to see if you could help them implement a process change with Scrum. You decide to give it a try.

The situation is quite different from what you expected. Although there is a Product Owner, there is no fixed team. Instead, people are pulled from a variety of other projects to participate in the process change for 2 days a week. Apparently, this can't be changed. Another thing that is quite different is the Increment. Instead of the tangible Increment that you're used to, it seems that this process change involves mostly abstract work. Some examples of the work suggested by the team are: "Update job descriptions", "Draft new legal framework for the renovation process" and "Deploy employee satisfaction survey".

As a Scrum Master, how can you creatively adapt to the situation in such a way that you can make Scrum work? What is possible, what is not? Imagine what you would do if you would be in the shoes of this Scrum Master.

#1

**What Would
You Do?**

“Can we drop Scrum Events?”

You've been working with a Scrum Team for over three months now. As a part-time Scrum Master, you've helped them start with Scrum and are now supporting them by facilitating the various Scrum Events.

On one of the days that you're not working with this team, you receive a call from one of the members. They want to talk about how useful Scrum is and have scheduled a meeting for it. Some of the ideas they already mentioned are to extend the Sprint to four weeks and to stop some of the Scrum Events. Specifically, they would like to do a Daily Scrum twice a week and do a Sprint Review and Sprint Retrospective every other Sprint. Everyone should attend, and they hope you'll be there too - even if this is not the day you're generally there.

Imagine that you're in the shoes of this Scrum Master. You just received this call: How do you respond? What do you feel? In a case like this, what is the single best strategy you can take? How does this connect to self-management and to the Scrum values?

#2

**What Would
You Do?**

Skipping the Retrospective in weekly Sprints

You work with a Scrum Team that has Sprints of a week. Up to this point, you've been doing an hour-long weekly Sprint Retrospective as part of this cycle. The Product Owner isn't always present due to scheduling conflicts. Also, the Developers suggests doing a Sprint Retrospective every other Sprint. Their experience is that the weekly Sprint Retrospectives don't really result in anything useful anyways.

As a Scrum Master, would you go along with the suggestion of the Developers? If yes, why? If no, why not? How does this connect to servant leadership and to self-management?

#3

**What Would
You Do?**

External supplier causes Sprint dependencies

The Scrum Team you're working with as a Scrum Master is waiting for an external supplier to do work that is required to move items to Done.

Until this is done, there isn't enough work to keep the entire team busy. In order to keep everyone busy and make the best use of the time, the Developers asks the Product Owner to reorder the Product Backlog so that there's more work to pick up.

As a Scrum Master, you see this unfold in front of you. What would you do? How does this connect to the responsibilities of the roles? Where do you see impediments?

#4

**What Would
You Do?**

“We’re almost there”

You are working with a Scrum Team that is doing Scrum to the letter. The team is in its 20th sprint. The Product Backlog is in tip-top shape, the Scrum Events are running smoothly and the Scrum Team has been collaborating effectively to reliably achieve their Sprint Goals. The product is coming together rapidly.

The Product Owner is driven, energetic, and has a strong vision. Being incredibly excited about the product, he has not yet invited any stakeholders to attend the Sprint Review. Although he intends to start doing so soon, he keeps pushing this into the next sprint with the argument: “We’re almost there. We just need a couple more features”.

How do you respond? Which Scrum values can guide your behavior? How? And how does this connect to empirical process control?

#5

**What Would
You Do?**

Low motivation of the Scrum Team

You recently joined an existing team. As their Scrum Master, you quickly notice that motivation is low. There is no drive to improve. Several members have told you in private that they have been unhappy with progress for a long time now. They are also unhappy with the quality of the codebase and the level of collaboration within the team.

These issues are never raised during 15-min Sprint Retrospectives, however. People mostly talk about what went well and give each other small compliments. But no actionable improvements are identified. The team is resisting to spend more time on the Sprint Retrospective, as they feel it is a waste of time.

If this is happening right in front of you, what would you do? How would you respond?

#6

**What Would
You Do?**

Unhappy Customers

Several important customers of your product are unhappy. Users are running into lots of bugs, performance is low and features are delivered well beyond set release dates.

Henry, the Product Owner of your team, agrees with this assessment. He asks you - as the Scrum Master - to resolve this with the Developers.

How would you respond to this request? How would you connect this to the Scrum values? What can you make transparent?

#7

**What Would
You Do?**

Suspend testing from the DoD

The company that you work for is about to release a highly anticipated product. A large marketing-campaign will support the release, further increasing the pressure. In order to include all the promised functionality, the Product Owner has decided to temporarily suspend testing from the Definition of Done. The Developers objects that this will cause technical debt.

To address this worry, the Product Owner and the Developers decide to add a placeholder-item ('Perform testing') on the Product Backlog.

What would you do? What questions would you ask? How does this case connect to the Scrum values and to the pillars of empiricism? What would be a good step forward?

#8

**What Would
You Do?**

What are good metrics?

You've been working as a Scrum Master for three different Scrum Teams for a while now. The teams all work on the same product, use the same technology, and work for the same group of stakeholders.

Recently, the manager of the teams has asked you to help her identify useful metrics to track their performance. Currently, no metrics are tracked. But she suggested tracking the number of hours worked and the number of items completed per Sprint.

What metrics would you suggest? How does this case connect to the Scrum values? What else would you do?

#9

**What Would
You Do?**

Resistance to Liberating Structures

"Can we just continue talking?" asks one of the members of your team when you suggest doing a 1-2-4-ALL to help them think. It's just one example of what you've seen happening more and more.

You've been using Liberating Structures for a while now. People seem to like the energy it brings. But some members are becoming increasingly frustrated with them. You feel uncertain about suggesting to try another Liberating Structure.

What would you do? Why might people be objecting to Liberating Structures? What can you change?

#10

What Would
You Do?

The technical Sprint Review

As a Scrum Master, you've been asked to support a Scrum Team that builds an API connector. One of the biggest challenges for this team is their Sprint Review. The team feels that the technical nature of their product makes it impossible to review it with stakeholders. So the Sprint Review usually takes the shape of a status update where the Product Owner's checks of what was done. Stakeholders are not present because nobody invites them.

And in all honesty, the team seems to have a point there. The API connector communicates exclusively with JSON. So the only meaningful thing they can show is JSON messages. And that doesn't mean anything to stakeholders.

Although the Scrum Team wants to improve, they see no way to include the stakeholders in a way that makes good use of their time.

How do you help this team? How does this connect to transparency, inspection, and adaptation? What questions would you ask this team or their stakeholders?

#11

**What Would
You Do?**

The external technical consultant

You work for an organization with ten Scrum Teams. Although most of them work on their own products, they all share the same technical infrastructure. In an effort to release more often, the head of the IT department has decided that it is time to implement continuous delivery. Instead of releasing once every four months, Scrum Teams should start releasing every month.

The Scrum Teams are skeptical of the idea to release more often, but they are willing to try it out. So the head of the IT department has brought in an external technical consultant to design and implement the new infrastructure using a variety of new technologies and frameworks. A proposal by the Scrum Teams to set this infrastructure up themselves is rejected by the IT department.

How would you deal with this? Where do the Scrum values come into play? How does this case impact the three pillars of Scrum; transparency, inspection, and adaptation? What else can you do?

#12

**What Would
You Do?**

How to deal with “almost Done”

You have been part of a Scrum Team for a while now. Most of the time, they are able to deliver a Done Increment at the end of the Sprint. But there are always some items from the Sprint Backlog that aren't completely finished. Your Scrum Team doesn't know how to deal with this during Sprint Planning. The developers prefer to simply move the item into the next Sprint, and complete it there. But the new items don't always make sense from the perspective of the Sprint Goal. Also, some developers feel that the item should be re-estimated. But the Product Owner doesn't agree and prefers to keep to the original estimate.

How do you deal with a situation like this? What can you make transparent? Where can you help the team inspect and adapt? What Scrum values come into play, and where?

#13

**What Would
You Do?**

“Can I skip the Daily Scrum?”

One of the members in your Scrum Team is consistently not showing up for the Daily Scrum. For her, it's just a waste of time and she prefers to just keep focused on her work. This bothers others Developers, but they also recognize how much work she gets done in 'focus mode'. You, and others in the team, have had conversations about this with her. But she has been unwilling to change her behavior.

How do you deal with a situation like this? What can you make transparent? How do the Scrum values inform your behavior? And what would servant leadership look like for you, in this case?

#14

**What Would
You Do?**

Scrum Master is responsible for performance reviews

The organization you work for implemented Scrum a couple of years ago. By using Scrum, many things have changed: new roles, events, and processes. Something that has stayed the same, are the annual performance reviews, for all the employees.

To respect the Scrum Team's autonomy, they have asked you to conduct these reviews. This means it's up to you to discuss the individual performance with each team member. Did they achieve their personal goals? Do they deserve an increase in salary? It's your call.

You're expected to have the individual performance reviews next Sprint.

If you would conduct the performance reviews, how would this impact your relationship with the Scrum Team? How would it change your role as a Scrum Master? How would it impact the Scrum values?

What would be an alternative approach?

#15

**What Would
You Do?**

Product Owner without a mandate

During Sprint #12, you're approached by the Product Owner of your Scrum Team. You can see she's angry. During the conversation she tells you that, once again, her decision to release the product this Sprint was overruled by a group of stakeholders. Also, they approached the Developers directly and told them to release next month and to include a different feature. The Product Owner learned about it this morning from a team member.

This isn't the first time this has happened.

Personally, you (and the Developers) have a good relationship with the Product Owner. Also, you're convinced that she is a great Product Owner. She's got all the necessary skills & capabilities, but she's struggling with organizational politics and power play by management.

You just wrapped up your conversation with the Product Owner. Something must change, but what? How would you approach this situation? What is something you would definitely do or not do? How does this situation impact the empirical process of Scrum, and what are the arguments you could raise with management?

#16

**What Would
You Do?**

What Should the Product Owner Do?

Three months ago, you started working as a Scrum Master for a Scrum Team. The collaboration with the Developers has been a smooth ride so far. But the story is different with the Product Owner.

The Product Owner is fairly new to the role. You've noticed that he spends most of his time writing out "User Stories" for the Product Backlog, often going to great lengths to capture all the relevant details. And even for items that are well down the Product Backlog. "I want to help the Developers by making it as clear and simple for them as possible", he says when you ask him why he does this. He seems satisfied with how he fulfills the role.

On the other hand, you notice that the Developers are increasingly frustrated. The product vision and strategy are missing, there are no Sprint Goals, and stakeholders rarely attend the Sprint Review. The Product Owner doesn't mind.

How would you approach this situation? What options do you see? How does this impact the responsibility you have as a Scrum Master?

#17

**What Would
You Do?**

Customer wants fixed scope project

The web agency you work for started using Scrum a couple of years ago. Although the agency itself fully embraces the Scrum framework, this is not the case for all clients.

For the past months, the Scrum Team is having a recurring conversation with a potential new client. It's a small entrepreneur with limited resources. Their product is promising and has a lot of potential. Given the limited financial resources, the client proposes to use a fixed budget. He wants to know if that's sufficient for the features they have in mind.

The Developers explain that many things are uncertain and unpredictable, so they can't give any guarantees, but most likely they can develop the majority of the features.

That's not enough for the client. They won't sign the contract until they have more guarantees. Management in your organization urges you, as a Scrum Master, to resolve this situation. They really want to help this client. And honestly, your company can use the revenue too.

If this was happening in your team, how would you move forward? What values of Scrum come into play? What is a conversation you could have with this client, when connecting it to empiricism?

#18

**What Would
You Do?**

To Scrum or not to Scrum?

As a freelance Scrum Master, you've recently been hired by the management of a bank to support two of their Scrum Teams. At first glance, all seems well. Both teams have a Product Owner, their technical capabilities and infrastructure are top-notch.

A few months in, a different picture has emerged. Where the process of working with Scrum works really well for one team, the other team is struggling. One area where this team struggles is when it comes to identifying a single unifying Sprint Goal for their Sprint Backlog. The top of their Product Backlog is usually an assortment of bugs, minor improvements, configuration tasks (e.g. changing user rights, setting up a new entity type), and occasionally larger changes.

You also notice problems in other areas. For example, there are no stakeholders present during the Sprint Reviews. The Daily Scrum lacks energy as people simply list what they will be working on. And there's always pressure on the team to pick up bugs and problems that happen during the Sprint, distracting them from their focus on the Sprint Backlog.

If you put on your Sherlock Hat, which areas would you investigate in particular? What questions would you ask, to Developers, the Product Owner and management? What recommendations can you make about how to improve the work with Scrum?

#19

**What Would
You Do?**

The focus of a Scrum Master

A large financial organization has invited you for a job interview as a Scrum Master. When you turn up, two people introduce themselves as the organization's Agile Coach and Enterprise Coach.

The Agile Coach explains that she focuses on coaching middle-management and the Enterprise Coach works with C-level executives. Your focus will become the Scrum Team. The three of you are expected to work as a 'coaching unit', each working on their own organizational level. During weekly synchronization meetups, you will discuss the progress with each other. The organization has several of these coaching units that drive the Agile transformation.

After having listened to the two coaches share their expectations & ideas, it's your turn to respond. How would you explain the responsibilities of the Scrum Master? What would you suggest? What is the good and bad of only focussing on Scrum Teams?

#20

**What Would
You Do?**

Scrum Master expectations

You've been hired as a Scrum Master for an organization that has been working with Scrum for six months. During the job interview, you discover their view on the Scrum Master role.

In a nutshell, Scrum Masters are expected to ensure Scrum is applied fully according to the Scrum Guide, exceptions should be called out. Scrum Masters should send in a weekly report and collect improvements during the Sprint Retrospective. Scrum Master must lead all the Scrum Events, make sure all the resources (post-its, markers, etc) are available, book the meetings rooms on time and keep track on the days off by team members.

If you were asked to fulfill the Scrum Master role like this, how would you respond? What would be the impact on the principles and values of Scrum? What would be a good next step?

#21

**What Would
You Do?**

The part-time Scrum Master

Your web-development shop started with Scrum a year ago. This was an idea raised by the Scrum Teams themselves. Although the founder was receptive to the idea, he asked that the role of the Scrum Master would be fulfilled for eight hours a week at most. Otherwise, the overhead would be too significant.

As a result, in most Scrum Teams, a developer, tester or analyst volunteered to spend eight hours a week acting as a Scrum Master. This time would be used to prepare & facilitate the Scrum events and update the Scrum board. After a while, the teams decided to rotate this responsibility.

A few months down the road, the role of the Scrum Master is brought up during a company-wide Retrospective. It's getting harder and harder to find volunteers.

Imagine attending this Retrospective, what would be a way to demonstrate the value of the Scrum Master? What ideas or suggestions would you raise?

#22

**What Would
You Do?**

Product Owner isn't available for the Developers

For the past years, Peter has acted as Product Owner for your Scrum Team. The relationship between Peter, the Developers, and you (the Scrum Master) has always been excellent.

Recently, Peter has been promoted to lead a large development initiative. As a result of this, he can spend much less time with the Developers.

You've noticed how this is starting to affect the Sprints. The Product Backlog isn't in tip-top shape anymore. Refinement happens less frequently and Peter struggles to come up with an objective for each Sprint. You also notice how Peter is increasingly skipping the Sprint Retrospective. Increasingly, the Sprint Review is the first opportunity for Peter to see what the Developers has been working on.

Despite his other commitments, Peter wants to continue as Product Owner. He has a good relationship with the Developers and doesn't want to abandon them.

How do you approach this situation? How will this most likely impact the Scrum framework and the Scrum values? What recommendations can you make?

#23

**What Would
You Do?**

“Please fill in the Sprint Report”

A large financial organization hired you as a Scrum Master. Scrum was introduced a year ago. According to the Project Management Office (PMO), they currently have 32 Scrum Teams. At the end of your first full Sprint with your Scrum Team, you receive an email from the PMO. It contains a detailed “Sprint Report template”. Each Scrum Master must gather the data, fill in the report and send it back to PMO so they can share it on the intranet. This is all done with the purpose of transparency, checking that Scrum Teams adhere to Scrum and to rank teams.

The “Sprint Report Template” contains the following questions:

1. How many times did the Developers do the Daily Scrum?
2. How much time has been spent on Scrum meetings?
3. How many user stories have been completed?
4. How many story points are done?
5. Do all the Product Backlog items for the next Sprint conform to the Definition of Ready?

What is made transparent by answering these questions? What information does this report offer you about how the Scrum Teams are working empirically? What would be an alternative approach or other questions to ask?

#24

**What Would
You Do?**

Physical or digital backlog?

Two years ago, when the first Scrum Teams were formed, teams put their Product Backlog and Sprint Backlog on the walls of their team space. The Daily Scrum was conducted in front of the physical Sprint Backlog and keeping it up-to-date was a shared responsibility. Having all the information transparent triggered lots of powerful & important conversations. Not only within the team but also with stakeholders and management.

However, the organization has grown rapidly and has 24 Scrum Teams today. Using physical backlogs has made synchronization between the teams more difficult. There are heaps of stickies everywhere. All the walls are covered, things are cluttering up. And for the people working from home it's difficult to get up-to-speed.

Everyone acknowledges the benefits of a physical backlog, but they can't ignore the current problems either. Therefore they are considering moving the backlog into a digital tool. They ask you, as a Scrum practitioner, for advice. What would be your recommendation? In your experience, what approach would still support empiricism and the Scrum values?

#25

**What Would
You Do?**

Clean desk & wall policy

Together with 3 other Scrum Masters you've been part of a "Scrum Safari", visiting three other organizations. The safari resulted in lots of inspiration and ideas.

Something that impressed the most was the concept of "creating an external memory". The organization you visited decided to make everything they considered worth remembering physically transparent. All the walls of the team spaces were covered with the Product & Sprint Backlog, improvements, impediments, dependencies, Sprint Goals, etc.

Inspecting the content and making adaptations was a shared effort. Not only by the team members, but stakeholders as well.

You and your fellow Scrum Masters are tremendously excited about this concept! However... your organization has a "clean office policy". Meaning that nothing can be put on walls. Otherwise, the teams might reveal 'sensitive' information and from a practical point of view: cleaning the office becomes much more difficult with stickies everywhere!

What are the arguments you could raise within your organization to support the concept of creating an external memory? How would it support empiricism? What would be the impact on the Scrum values?

#26

**What Would
You Do?**

Scrum for Hardware

You've been hired as the Scrum Master for a company that develops time punch-clocks and associated products. The Scrum Team that is about to be formed will be developing both the software and the hardware for a new series of bluetooth-enabled clocks.

Although the software can be developed in-house, the clocks themselves are built in a remote factory based on specifications provided by your team. Because the factory also works for other customers, it generally takes two months for a new prototype to be delivered.

The mix of hardware and software puts you in a tricky spot. You wonder what a Done increment should look like for this team, and what should be on the Definition of Done? If you are the Scrum Master of this team, what would you focus on?

#27

What Would
You Do?

The CTO wants to do things differently

You've recently been asked to join an ambitious startup as a Scrum Master. They have been at it for a few years, growing rapidly and expanding into new markets. From the very start, the developers and the Product Owners have been organized into small teams that are in close contact with their customers and end-users. The quality of the codebase is top-notch and releases happen every day.

But there are growing pains. Now that the startup is expanding into international markets, and customers become more demanding, an experienced CTO has been hired to oversee the technical aspects of product development.

In her first weeks, she decides to make several significant changes. The first is that developers should no longer interact directly with stakeholders, and leave this to the Product Owner. This creates a clear "chain of information" and can keep developers focused on their work. Another change is that releases should now only happen at the end of a Sprint, and not intermittently. The CTO hopes that this will reduce breaking issues and simplify communication about releases.

You can sense that the Scrum Teams are not happy with the changes. But nobody is expressing this. What conversations are you going to have right away? How do certain Scrum values come into play in your behavior? How might the decisions of the CTO impact empiricism?

#28

**What Would
You Do?**

Scrum doesn't work for repetitive work?

You are the Scrum Master of several Scrum Teams. Although you've been working with Scrum for a while, things haven't been going as smoothly as you hoped.

Most of the work that your teams do revolves around the configuration of product modules that have been developed by other teams. Since the modules, and their configuration, are mostly the same across customers, the work is quite repetitive. In the rare cases that issues are found, they are simply passed back to development. When your team is done with the configuration, another team actually installs the packages.

Although the teams appreciate how Scrum has created cadence for them and reduced the amount of ad-hoc work, they are less convinced of the value of the Scrum Events. It feels like a waste of time to them. One of the members of your team recently stated that Scrum simply doesn't work for repetitive work. This has made you wonder; is Scrum the right framework for this team?

If you are the Scrum Master of this team, what would you explore? How does repetitive work fit within the Scrum framework? When you take a broad picture of this organization, what would you focus on in your inquiries?

#29

**What Would
You Do?**

The developers are only here to code

You are the Scrum Master of three Scrum Teams. Each team has a mix of developers, analysts, testers, and designers. Recently, the teams expressed a desire to work more collaboratively on items. Right now, everyone is mostly working in their own area of expertise.

But friction immediately follows. When one of the analysts asks two developers to join him on a trip to a customer, the developers respond with chagrin. “This is your job”, they say. A similar point is made during the next Sprint Retrospective, where the developers air their frustration with having spent a lot of time on “unrelated tasks”. For example, one developer spent a day reviewing potential test cases for the product with the tester. Another developer had to spend the better portion of the week fixing UI issues caused by the designer.

There is a lot of tension in the team. What do you, right now, as a Scrum Master? What question do you ask? How can you model Scrum values in your behavior? What is a really bad idea?

#30

**What Would
You Do?**

Different Definition of Done's

The company you've been working on is scaling up its effort to deliver an upcoming product that processes banking transactions. Plans are to scale from three to ten Scrum Teams, each working on a separate component of the same product. You've been asked to support this process and make sure that it works.

One of the first things you do is host a workshop to develop a Definition of Done with the teams. After going back and forth on this for a while, the teams settle on an approach where each team has their own Definition of Done. This gives each team the greatest flexibility and allows them to get their work done without having to depend on the other teams. Another reason why they think this works well is because each team adheres to different quality standards. Having a shared Definition of Done would be impractical and cause delays.

What are your thoughts? How could this decision impact transparency? If you take the perspective of a stakeholder of this product, what might a consequence be for them?

#31

**What Would
You Do?**

Scrum creates commitment?

As an external Scrum Master, you've been hired to support three existing Scrum Teams. The teams have been working with Scrum for a while now, but progress has been minimal. One of the biggest challenges has been to create a "Done" Increment every Sprint.

According to the team manager, the Scrum Teams are not taking sufficient responsibility. Instead, he feels, they are merely pointing fingers at other teams and management for their own inability to get their work done. "It would help", he says, "if the Scrum Master would remind them of their responsibilities and put more pressure on them to get things done".

Sensing tension between the team manager and the teams, you propose to facilitate an open conversation between them. But the team manager categorically refuses to participate. The problem is with the teams, not with him.

How do you proceed? Where do you put pressure on the Scrum Teams, and how? What questions can you ask both parties? What would you inspect and adapt? What else could be going on here?

#32

**What Would
You Do?**

How to define Product Backlog items?

A Scrum Team in your organization is looking for a way to capture requirements for a new product on their Product Backlog. You've been invited to join a conversation in which they explore different ideas on which approach to use.

One of the developers suggests to use User Stories, mostly because this format ("As a... I want... so that...") is used by most other teams as well. Another developer raises the idea of "Use Cases". Another prefers "Job Stories". The Product Owner prefers not to fix to any approach and to determine on a case-by-case basis what makes sense. The team isn't excited about this idea, and prefers to stick to one approach to keep things simple.

When it comes to capturing requirements, what recommendations can you make to the Scrum Team? What is most important about gathering requirements on a Product Backlog, and how can the team use these considerations in their trade-off?

#33

**What Would
You Do?**

Scrum Master of Five Teams

During a job interview, you learn that the organization expects you to become a Scrum Master of five teams simultaneously. Although they understand that one Scrum Master for each team might be better, they simply can't afford it. It's a small company with limited resources. So they ask you to consider becoming a Scrum Master for five teams.

The Scrum Teams aren't experienced. They only use Scrum for a couple of months. Each team has about 3 - 4 members. All teams have the same Product Owner, given that they work on the same product as well.

How would you respond during this job interview? What questions would you ask or what feedback would you give? How would you prefer moving forward?

#34

What Would
You Do?

Happy Clappy Scrum

"Let's win the Best Workplaces Award!", says the CEO of the organization you started working for as a Scrum Master. Earlier this year, the organization completed a large reorganization. Many employees had to leave. The process was emotional for everyone involved and had a huge impact on performance.

To improve the atmosphere, management decided to introduce Scrum. One of the consultants that was hired by your company explains it as a way to improve happiness, create energy, and make working together fun again. The key metric they suggest is "team happiness" and how many high fives happen during Scrum Events.

During a brainstorm, you are asked to come up with ways to make the Sprint Review more fun. Right now, it is mostly the team sitting around a table, staring at a screen.

Imagine that you participate in this brainstorming session. What is something you say or do? How does the goal of increasing team happiness align with your understanding of the Scrum framework? How can Scrum help win the Best Workplaces Awards?

#35

**What Would
You Do?**

Rotating the Scrum Master role

You've been approached by an organization that started with Scrum a couple of months ago. They are curious to learn what you see, hear, and notice in how Scrum is used. Something that immediately strikes you is that they rotate the role of the Scrum Master. You learn that this decision was made by the Developers.

Management initially raised their concerns about this choice, but didn't want to impede the managing capabilities of the Developers. Eventually, they settled on being happy that this saved them the need to hire a dedicated Scrum Master.

You interview the Developers about their decision. They explain that the designated Scrum Master is responsible for facilitating the Scrum Events, updating the Scrum board and gathering the data for the Sprint report. Nobody likes doing this, so they decided to all share in the burden.

After having interviewed multiple teams, management wants to know your opinion. What problem are they solving by rotating the role of the Scrum Master? What is your experience with frequently changing the Scrum Master role?

#36

**What Would
You Do?**

We don't want Sprint Goals

"I just don't see how to create a Sprint Goal out of this", says your Product Owner with clear exasperation in her voice. It's been an ongoing struggle, really. You've been pushing the Scrum Team to create Sprint Goals, but they just don't see how.

The work that the Scrum Team has to do for their product is a mixed bag. There are some small new features, appended by a lot of bugs and smaller issues. The team is also running into a lot of ad-hoc work that has to be addressed right away, like breaking bugs and other changes that demand immediate attention. Although there is a Product Backlog, and it is ordered, the items on it are hardly related.

What could be going on here? How would you explain the value of Sprint Goals? Where would you direct your energy to as a Scrum Master?

#37

**What Would
You Do?**

The Definition of Done becomes less ambitious

It has been a year since you started as a Scrum Master for team “Moonwalkers”. Back then, one of your first activities was giving a short explanation of Scrum and its purpose: reduce risk, and provide value sooner by delivering a Done increment every Sprint. This became the team's mantra. They even created a large banner which is placed on top of the Scrum board.

Today, team morale is low. Everyone still believes in the importance of delivering Done increments every Sprint. But it just doesn't seem possible in this organization. For the past months, they always end with an “Almost Done” Sprint Backlog.

During the Sprint Retrospective, one team member suggested lowering the expectations and making the Definition of Done less ambitious. “Of course, I want to deliver high-quality products! But what good is it, if we never finish anything?!” Simon, one of the developers says.

Imagine that you are the Scrum Master of this team, what would you say or do? How could you help this team move forward? What are useful tactics or experiments to explore?

#38

**What Would
You Do?**

“Don’t expect us to do Scrum”

You’ve been asked to become the Scrum Master for an existing engineering team. As part of the ambition to use Scrum throughout the company, this team is expected to do so as well.

On your first day, while introducing yourself, you’re approached by Bob, one of the senior engineers. “You have to understand ...” he starts “... that we have our own way of getting things done in this team.”. He continues “This Scrum-stuff will come and go. It’s just another change initiative that happens every now and then. We’ll play along, but don’t expect us to change anything. Our approach is just fine! It was 15 years ago, and it still is today!”. He clearly has strong feelings about this.

When you talk to the other members of your team, you get similar responses. This is not how you imagined your first day. On your way home, you’re wondering how to approach this situation.

How does resistance manifest in this case? How else can you consider this? What is something you would do next? What is something you would definitely not do?

#39

**What Would
You Do?**

Sprints are packed with too much work

Since you joined team “Rock Stars” two months ago, you noticed a clear pattern. The team isn’t having lunch together. Usually, people quickly eat behind their desks. It’s also not uncommon for people to pull through in the evening. The various Scrum Events are usually considered as annoyances that get in the way of work.

The Sprint Planning shows a clear pattern as well. The Product Owner is always in the lead. He has already prepared the Sprint Backlog in advance and explains each item in great detail. After each item he asks the team for commitment to complete. In practice, this always results in a “yes”. Once the Product Owner has received commitment on all items, the Sprint Planning is closed and everyone starts work.

Everyone does seem to have a good relationship with the Product Owner. He’s charismatic, but can be persuasive and persistent as well. You’re convinced that something has to change. What do you do, right now, as a Scrum Master? What question do you ask? How can you model Scrum values in your behavior? What is a really bad idea?

#40

What Would
You Do?

People don't wait for the organization to change

It's already one year ago that you started working for a large financial organization. In total, they have over 10.000 employees across the globe. When you arrived, the Agile transformation was already going on for a couple of years. Everyone in the organization understands the importance of the transformation. They can't quickly respond to changes in the market, shipping new features takes months, and struggle with the many legacy-systems. The organization feels like a sinking ship.

As one of the (many) Scrum Masters, they expect you to support this Agile transformation. The organization used to have a reputation for having the most talented employees. But many are leaving to competitors. The same dynamic is going on within your Scrum Team. In the beginning, everyone was enthusiastic about helping the organization change. But the organization is changing so slowly, that everyone gets demotivated and frustrated. The #1 topic at the coffee machine are the latest vacancies at other companies. They even ask you for recommendations.

You've got mixed feelings. You want to Agile transformation to be successful, but can't blame your team members for not having patience. What would you do in this situation?

#41

What Would
You Do?

“Let's prepare for the first Sprint”

You've been working for a web agency already for five years. It's an awesome company, with many cool clients for whom they build complex software products. The teams have been working with Scrum for over three years now. The Scrum Events are generally productive, there are clear Sprint Goals and most Sprints result in a Done increment.

However, there's one thing you're not happy with. For each new project, the teams schedule something they call a “preparation Sprint”. This Sprint is conducted before the contract with a new client is signed. During this Sprint, the Scrum Team works with the client to write the specifications for the product, create an architectural blueprint and develop an initial design. Only when the client is satisfied with the outcome, the contract is signed for all future Sprints.

This close collaboration with the client is a big advantage. However, the client often thinks that once the preparation Sprint is done, no more changes will be needed and only a couple of “Development Sprints” will suffice to actually develop the product. This has resulted in quite a few tough conversations.

Although clients like these “preparation Sprints”, you're looking for a different approach. What are the pitfalls of these kinds of Sprints? How does it impact your ability to work empirically? What alternative can you suggest to clients, your team and management?

#42

**What Would
You Do?**

The designer works one Sprint ahead

The Scrum Team you joined three months ago, has all the skills to develop software development products. The team has front-end developers, back-end developers, testers, an architect and a designer. Although everyone has their own specialization, they are willing to learn from each other and take on other tasks as well.

The only person not joining this cross-functional approach is the designer. She is usually working on her own, making designs for future Product Backlog items. The designs help clients better understand upcoming functionality of the product. To such an extent, that when clients see the design, they think it's already done. Not understanding it has to be fully built yet. Also, designs are sometimes made for work that meanwhile has become outdated and removed from the Product Backlog. This feels like wasted time for the designer.

During the Sprint Retrospective, the Scrum Team, including the designer, want to explore an alternative approach. They ask you, as the Scrum Master, for advice.

What is your experience with making design-work part of the Scrum Team? What would be an approach that would help the team work more empirically? What would you suggest in this case?

#43

**What Would
You Do?**

Stakeholders Troubles

You recently joined an organisation that develops highly specialized software for police departments. The departments act as stakeholders of the product while also funding its continued development. There are no other investors.

This approach worked well for a while. Recently, however, the departments increasingly have different ideas on how to move forward. You've also noticed how they are all putting pressure on the Product Owner and the Developers to give preference to the work from the Product Backlog that benefits them. Increasingly, the Product Owner is bowing to demands from one of the police departments in particular. The other departments are unhappy with this and are threatening to halt their funding altogether.

The Product Owner asks for your help.

If you put yourself in the shoes of this Scrum Master, what would you do? What could be going on in this team? What recommendations would you make?

#44

**What Would
You Do?**

A founders dream or nightmare?

It has been two years ago, since the web-agency's founder, Michael, shared his vision with the Scrum Teams. They should become fully autonomous, take complete ownership of the product they're developing and become responsible for their own profit & loss.

Although the developers were hesitant in the beginning, nowadays, they've embraced Michael's vision. The Scrum Teams hire new team members themselves, upgrade technology when necessary, and do all sales on their own.

But recently, something happened that shocked Michael. An interview with one of the teams was published in which they didn't mention the company's name even once. Only the self-chosen names of the teams were included. The comment "a logical next step would be to start our own company" raised all the alarm bells! This wasn't what Michael had considered two years ago...

This afternoon, Michael wants to discuss the interview with the Scrum Masters. He wants to hear your thoughts as well. What is your take on this situation? How does the team's behavior connect to the Scrum values?

#45

**What Would
You Do?**

Management creates the Scrum Teams

The head of your organization wants to introduce Scrum. Currently, work is organized mostly into functional departments. So there is a department for testing, one for coding and one for architecture and analysis. It has been impressed on management to create cross-functional teams where various skill-sets and specialties are mixed.

As a coach and experienced Scrum Master, the company asks for your help with team formation. The heads of the various departments have already spent a couple of days together to create potential teams. In the process, they've also identified some employees that they are willing to let go of. Their worry is that these employees will resist the change. The department heads have also worked hard to take into interpersonal relationships, skills, personalities and personal ambitions. But they're not happy with the result and are looking for your recommendations. They hope you can offer some quick tips, as time is of the essence and the Scrum Teams need to start in a couple of days.

What recommendations do you have? What are the benefits of the current approach? What are benefits of other approaches? What would be your first step?

#46

**What Would
You Do?**

A special guest for the Sprint Retrospective

The CEO in your company has been a strong advocate of Scrum for years. When he joined, the company was only 100 people strong. Now, there are thousands of employees all over the world.

In an effort to connect more closely with the experience of Scrum Teams, he has asked if he can join the upcoming Sprint Retrospective of your team on one of his upcoming “Gemba Walks”. This is an exciting opportunity, as people don’t regularly get to meet the CEO.

As the Scrum Master of this team, how do you respond to this request?

#47

**What Would
You Do?**

Improving estimation of capacity

You have been working with a Scrum Team for a while. One of the challenges your team keeps running into is how to determine their capacity for a Sprint. Having staked their professional pride in delivering a Done increment at the end of a Sprint, they want to make sure they can deliver on their promise. For this, they need a good sense of how much time they have every Sprint. But that capacity is influenced by many factors, including vacations, days off, time spent on training and workshops that are unrelated to the product and time spent in meetings.

The current approach of your team is to look ahead for the coming Sprint, sum all the hours spent on vacation, time off, training and other non-work, and subtract that from their total capacity in hours. The selection of their work is based on the remaining capacity. Although it works, the team still frequently underestimates how much time they lose during a Sprint.

The Product Owner agrees that an accurate estimation of capacity is useful and implores the team to be honest and open about the capacity they have. Having failed to find a good solution on their own, they ask you - their Scrum Master - for help.

As their Scrum Master, how can you help this team? What recommendations can you make? What would you change in terms of how events are scheduled and how long they are?

#48

**What Would
You Do?**

What is the value the Scrum Master delivers?

You work as a Scrum Master for a large retailer. In a push towards increased agility, your organization has started adopting Scrum for product development a few years ago. To expand these efforts, other departments are now also switching to agile-oriented approaches.

This includes your HR department. In an attempt to work more empirically, they feel that it is helpful for employees to measure and demonstrate their value. So they've asked representatives from the various roles to think about how this could be done.

As one of the Scrum Masters, you've been asked to offer suggestions for how to measure the and demonstrate the value of your role. What metrics can the HR-department start using to determine if a Scrum Master is adding value to the organization? How should these metrics be used?

With your knowledge and experience with Scrum, what metrics would you recommend? What other considerations do you have?

#49

**What Would
You Do?**

We need this customer!

One of your clients approaches your company with a request to build a customer portal for them. The request includes a detailed overview of specifications, and asks for a planning and a price. You know that several competitors have been approached with the same request. The customer has no experience with Scrum.

Your internal Product Owner is struck with a dilemma. On the one hand, he wants to recognize the complexity of the work and avoid a detailed proposal with a fixed price. At the same time, your company is in need of more work to generate more revenue. So it's important to “land” this customer. Aware of your experience with Scrum, the Product Owner asks for your help.

What risks may emerge here? In light of that, what approach could you offer your Product Owner that balances the wicked challenge posed by this customer? Which parts of Scrum would you sacrifice?

#50

**What Would
You Do?**

Sprint Planning, Interrupted

You are the Scrum Master of four Scrum Teams that work for a large banking institution in Switzerland. The work that you do is highly regulated. For an upcoming Sprint, your Scrum Team will be working on an important new feature in the banking app. For this important occasion, the department manager will join too. He has asked the Product Owner for the opportunity to join for a while now. Seeing no harm, the Product Owner agreed to let him join.

But things turn out differently. Not long after Sprint Planning starts, tension starts to build. It begins right after the Product Owner states her objective for the coming Sprint. Visibly annoyed, the department manager raises his voice and states that he is not pleased with what he sees. In his eyes, the Product Owner is making a bad call and is focussing on the wrong things. A verbal dispute ensues as the Product Owner and the department manager argue about the best way forward, while the Developers try to draw as little attention as possible.

You propose a brief coffee break for everyone to calm down. During the break, the department manager approaches you with an urgent request to take control of Sprint Planning and re-orient the team to what really matters.

How do you respond to this situation? What considerations come into play? How can you behave in a way that aligns with the Scrum values?

#51

**What Would
You Do?**

The curious case of two Product Owners

You are part of a new Scrum Team that works for a web agency. Together with four other Scrum Teams, your team builds public-facing web applications and mobile apps for customers.

Generally, each team works on different projects and for different customers. But every now and then, teams work together on larger projects. The teams range between 5 and 8 members and can perform all the required work (design, analysis, testing, coding). Projects vary greatly in length. Some are completed in a few weeks, others take one or two months.

The journey into Scrum is recent for your company. Although every team has a Scrum Master and performs the various Scrum Events, it has been challenging to fulfill the role of the Product Owner. Your CEO is convinced that the role of the Product Owner should be fulfilled by someone from the customer-organization. Because teams generally work on multiple projects at the same time due to delays in the customer-organization, this would mean that there are multiple Product Owners for each team. Alternatively, the Scrum Master has proposed to hire a single Product Owner per team to create focus and protect the interests of your agency. The various customers would then become the stakeholders of this Product Owner.

If you take an empirical approach into consideration, what recommendations would you make when it comes to the role of the Product Owner? What alternative solutions do you see? What are possibilities this agency doesn't see, yet?

#52

About The Liberators

We - Barry Overeem and Christiaan Verwijs - aim to liberate individuals, teams, and organizations from de-humanizing and ineffective ways of organizing work by putting them in control of shaping their future.

We take a radical approach to organizational change. Rather than taking the lead, we empower people within organizations to drive change themselves. We create space where people can tackle difficult challenges together while also having fun. Inspired by the fields of complexity science and organizational psychology, we use frameworks like Scrum, Lean Change Management and Liberating Structures to deliver fast-paced interactions, high involvement and creative destruction.

- Visit our website: <https://theliberators.com>
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If you received this deck of cases for free, please consider [a donation](#) to support us if it was valuable to you. We invested sixty hours in writing, reviewing and iterating the cases. Most of our content is available for free, and we rely on your support to make more of it.

A stylized, abstract graphic featuring a rainbow with orange, pink, and white bands, set against a bright yellow background. The rainbow is framed by a dark blue border. The graphic is composed of thick, bold lines and is centered in the upper half of the page.

The Liberators

Unleashing Organisational Superpowers